



Turning Point

When Vishal Dadlani, music director and vocalist of rock band Pentagram, said Nair could manage their gigs. He was then 19 years old.

“WE WANT TO TAKE MUSIC BANDS TO THE REMOTEST corner of the country. Most of India hasn’t seen a live band perform. That’s our next big leap.”

VIJAY NAIR, MUSIC ENTREPRENEUR, 25

Low-cost airlines may not have realised this, but Only Much Louder (OML) founder Vijay Nair says they’ve helped Indian rock bands tremendously. Nair, who heads India’s premier artist management company, says that bands can now perform all over India. And when he says that, it’s hard not to believe it. As the go-to guy for a majority of rock bands, he should know. His company now has a full-fledged independent record label, Counter Culture Records, and last year, Nair organised close to a hundred gigs across the country.

Nair started early, dropping out of Mumbai’s Sydenham College after a year and getting his first paycheque

when he sold his website masti.com. At 18, he met Sandeep Mittal from Gigpad, a website that promotes rock. Within weeks, he began managing the band Acquired Funk Syndrome. That was 2002. Today, OML manages India’s biggest rockers, including Them Clones and Pentagram. Nair recently won the British Council Young Music Entrepreneur of 2009 award. For the first five years, OML was a one-man show, but now it’s a team of 20 people, working across production company Babblefish and their newest kid on the block, OML Digital, which will create a platform for budding musicians to put their music online. With the Indian plan in place, OML has already started taking artistes for performances in South-east Asia and the UK.

But a job that doesn’t fit into a strict definition wasn’t easy to understand for his traditional parents. He isn’t sure whether they still understand what he does. “They just tell everyone I’m a musician.” But they have supported him at every step. The Nair residence in Mumbai is the most popular guest house with rock bands. “My mother may not listen to their music but she knows all the rockers.” And it’s safe to say all of them know Nair.

by Jhilmil Motihar